



“ The real bottleneck in the growth of FOSS in India is inadequate and commercially sustainable deployment with 'real world users' ”

C N Krishnan, programme director, AU-KBC (Anna University-K B Chandrashekar) Research Centre, Anna University

Under Anna University's new two-year online distance education programme (<http://cde.annauniv.edu/MSCFOSS/>), students can pursue an M.Sc in FOSS (Computer Science – Free and Open Source Software). This programme is the only degree from a leading Indian technology-focused university that's specifically being awarded for studies in FOSS. In the process of becoming a computer science professional through this programme, one also masters a wide range of products, tools, technologies and approaches thrown up by the FOSS movement. Moreover, it is the only such programme from a leading Indian tech university delivered entirely online. It has the benefits of flexible interactive learning unconstrained by geographical limitations and is specially suited for those who are already working.

C N Krishnan, programme director, AU-KBC (Anna University-K B Chandrashekar) Research Centre, Anna University, spoke to **Diksha P Gupta** of **LfY Bureau**, about the course and the impact of open source software on Indian society. Excerpts:

Q What has your journey in the open source world been like?

We at AU-KBC Research Centre in Anna University, Chennai, started this initiative to promote FOSS in higher education back in 2003. At some stage we realised that this was indeed a huge task, and we would need strong partners and funds to make any significant impact. That is where M R Rajagopalan, director, CDAC Chennai Centre, stepped forward as an enthusiastic collaborator and we jointly submitted a Project Proposal to the D.I.T./MCIT, GoI in late 2003. Perhaps because this was not a routine R&D proposal that DIT normally funds, our joint proposal (Anna University and CDAC Chennai) was not cleared till 2005. Once the project was cleared with good funding, we could start some serious long-term plans for FOSS promotion.

We at Anna University then focused on various ways of introducing FOSS concepts and technologies into universities and colleges, while CDAC concentrated on developing and

deploying FOSS technologies and solutions. Other than conducting a strong FOSS awareness campaign amongst the academia, we introduced FOSS courses (for theory as well as labs) as part of the curricula of the CSE/IT/MCA courses of a number of universities in the country. We also offered student projects and mentorships in FOSS, produced content useful for formal education in FOSS, etc. We believe about 600-700 colleges in the country have been enabled to teach FOSS courses as part of their curricula, if they so desire.

Since 2009, the NRCFOSS Network has seen significant expansions, and in the current Phase-II, which is ongoing, there are seven institutions running the programme (<http://www.nrcfoss.org.in/>). At the AU-KBC Centre we need to raise revenues to sustain the FOSS promotion work beyond the DIT funding; so we have also started a 'FOSS Technologies and Solutions Deployment Programme', in addition to our ongoing 'FOSS in Higher Education' programme (<http://nrcfoss.au-kbc.org.in/>). We provide